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Article Title: Using Identity Work Theory to Understand the De-escalation of Fandom: A Study of Former Fans of National Hockey League Teams

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Abstract

A de-escalation of team fandom model was created based on identity work theory. In order to both test the model and understand how once highly-identified fans of sports teams could eventually become non-fans, 23 former fans of National Hockey League (NHL) teams were interviewed. The reasons given for their de-escalation in fandom can be categorized into seven themes: sport in general, the sport of hockey, the league, the team, individual players, media, and life. For those fans who remain fans of the sport, watching national teams play in international competition has been a common practice in the years since the bond with their former favorite NHL team was severed. While only a minority of participants believes it realistically possible they could ever become NHL team fans again in the future, some suggested their children or grandchildren might pull them back into fandom.

Introduction

There has been a tremendous amount of scholarship chronicling the bond between fans and their favorite teams (Wann, 2006). Researchers note that team-fan bonds can be comprised of bonds fans have with various team-related points of attachment or brand associations, such as the team's players, venue, or logo, the sport played or the city represented (e.g., Gladden & Funk, 2001). Theorists have not only defined and measured fan identification with sport teams (or such related concepts as loyalty or commitment), but have also examined its antecedents and consequences (see Wann, 2006 for a summary). The research questions typically involve understanding the thoughts, feelings, or behaviors of identified team fans (e.g., Gibson, Willming, & Holdnak, 2002). While thoughts, feelings, and behaviors are separate constructs, theorists have noted that highly identified fans of sport teams (versus casual consumers of sport) typically have both strong positive attitudes (composed of thoughts and feelings) towards their favorite team and relatively high levels of behavior directed towards it (Funk & James, 2001; Gladden & Funk, 2001; Mahony, Madrigal, & Howard, 1999). This conceptualization of a highly identified fan is in keeping with the conceptualization of a highly loyal consumer as found in marketing's brand loyalty literature, where brand loyalty is thought to consist of both a strong, positive attitude to a brand of goods or services, and the repeat purchasing of it (Day, 1969, Dick & Basu, 1994; Jacoby & Chestnut, 1978). Based partly on these empirical studies of fans, sport consumer behavior scholars have developed prescriptions about how practitioners can strengthen team-fan bonds to build larger and more loyal fan bases (Foster & Hyatt, 2008; Gladden & Funk, 2001; Lock, Taylor, Funk, & Darcy, 2012).

While there has been a significant amount of sport fan identification research, most is based on the assumption fans either maintain a consistent identification level, or see their

identification escalate over time. Yet, some researchers have recognized that the attachment people have with sport teams may wane, which may result in the breaking of these bonds (Funk & James, 2001; Mullin, Hardy, & Sutton, 2007). These scholars have called for more academic research to understand how teams can end up losing their emotional grip on their fans. Our study is designed to help answer that call.

We begin by reviewing both the brand loyalty literature and the pertinent sport consumer behavior literature. We then introduce identity work theory and our model of fan de-escalation in an attempt to explain how the severing of the team-fan bond is the result of a misalignment of fan values and/or barriers to fan practices. Next, we explain our methods and the empirical strategies used when examining our data. The findings of the seven themes are then discussed, as are other findings relevant to our secondary research questions. The findings are used to test the final two stages of our model (disrupting fandom and de-escalating) that are directly related to the research questions. We conclude by discussing the findings' implications, the project's limitations, and directions for future research.

Review of Literature

Brand Loyalty

Marketers have long attempted to understand consumer loyalty to brands of products and services (Day, 1969; Jacoby & Chestnut, 1978), and this literature provides a fruitful frame of reference if we conceptualize the team-fan bond in terms of brand loyalty. Marketers attempting to understand why consumers would reduce their commitment to specific brands would then need to understand both the antecedents and moderators of brand loyalty (Chaudhuri & Holbrook, 2001).

Marketers Dick and Basu (1994) proposed a conceptual framework that suggested brand loyalty consists of a strong relative attitude towards the brand and repeat patronage of it. They noted three categories of brand loyalty antecedents: cognitive (e.g., the degree to which the brand aligns with the consumer’s values), affective (e.g., emotions involving arousal), and conative (e.g., switching costs). They also note that brand loyalty can be moderated by social norms (e.g., modifying one’s behavior based on what significant others think) and situational factors (e.g., the brand’s availability at time of purchase). Therefore changes to any of the antecedents or moderators can reduce one’s commitment to the brand. Much fan loyalty research is based on conceptualizations found in marketing’s brand loyalty literature (e.g., Funk & James, 2001; Mahony et al., 1999)

The Escalation of Fandom

While much sport fan research is based on cross-sectional studies of fans at one point in time where changes in fandom over time are not the focus (Gladden & Funk, 2001; Trail, Robinson, & Kim, 2008; Wakefield & Wann, 2006), the literature contains two pivotal theories addressing how fandom may evolve into increasingly higher levels of identification, commitment, and consumption behavior. Funk and James’ (2001) Psychological Continuum Model (PCM) suggests team fans first become *aware* the team exists, then become *attracted* to it, then find themselves *attached*, and finally become *allegiant*. At each stage, the psychological commitment strengthens. They conclude, however, by saying, “One area that has not been explored is movement downward- when an allegiant fan begins to reduce his or her connection to a team” (Funk & James, 2001, p. 144). Similar to Funk and James, Mullin, Hardy, and Sutton note some highly involved sport consumers might “dropout” (Mullin et al., 2007, p. 88). Their frequency escalator- a behavior-oriented model of sport consumption- suggests that as fans

become more involved with and committed to a team, they will follow it more frequently, either through the media or by live spectating. The sport marketer’s goal is to move fans up the escalator to consume more of the sport product. While noting theorists who explained why youth sport participants stop participating and become dropouts, they add, “...we know relatively little about adult dropouts....We can only guess how many sports fans drop off the escalator of present-day involvement and live in the world of memories. What prompts voluntary dropouts? There is much to learn...” (Mullin et al., 2007, p. 88).

The De-escalation of Fandom

The potential existence of adult dropouts and the possible downward movement of fans raise the question as to what might lead to de-escalation, and some research has explored this issue. Smith, Patterson, Williams, and Hogg (1981) asked a sample of 52 committed sports fans if they could conceive of circumstances under which their interest in sports might diminish. Seventy-seven percent of respondents said no. The others mentioned greedy players, legal issues, or a major change in family commitments might diminish future interest. While this research is a starting point, it is limited in that the results are based on speculation, not on actual experience. In two other studies, evidence suggested identification levels can decrease depending on both team and fan behavior. Fink, Parker, Brett and Higgins (2009) found team management’s improper handling of a player scandal can result in decreased fan identification. Drayer, Shapiro, Dwyer, Morse, and White (2010) found fantasy sport participation could lower fans’ team identification. Both studies suggest that in certain circumstances fans’ team identification can decline. In neither case, however, was the bond necessarily broken.

The Severing of the Team-Fan Bond

As for the complete severing of the team-fan bond, both Mahony et al. (1999), and Harada and Mastuoka (1999) note conditions under which previously loyal team fans will stop identifying with a former favorite team and switch loyalties to another team in the same league. Wann, Tucker, and Schrader (1996) asked participants to list the reasons they stopped following a former favorite team. The top five were: the team was no longer successful, they developed other commitments or lacked time, the loss of certain players, geographical reasons, and friends/peers no longer followed the team. A limitation of the study is it is unknown if the former favorite team is in the same league as a current favorite. As such, it is not possible to discern how many fans were “dropouts” in the spirit of Mullin et al. (2007), and how many merely switched loyalties from one team to another in the same league.

There has been some investigation of the team-fan bond being severed and not necessarily being replaced with a similar bond with another team in the same league. Mitrano (1999), Lewis (2001), and Hyatt (2007) studied the effect of franchise relocation on the left-behind fans, noting that fandom ended for many. What distinguishes these studies from previous research is they identify the trauma caused by the loss of a team as a key event leading to the severing of the team-fan bond. The limitation to these findings is that each study suggests fandom can be extinguished through events that cause trauma or psychological scarring and not necessarily through other more mundane occurrences.

Identity Work Theory

Our proposed model of sport fan de-escalation is based on identity work theory. It has been observed that a person’s identity involves “work” (Lawrence & Suddaby, 2006; Lawrence, Suddaby & Leca, 2009; Quinn-Trank & Washington, 2009). Identity work is the process of,

“people being engaged in the forming, repairing, maintaining, strengthening or revising the constructions that are productive of a sense of coherence and distinctiveness” (Sveningsson & Alvesson, 2003, p. 1165). This approach advocates identity as a process that involves a set of practices and behaviors. And, for an identity to endure over time, these practices and behaviors have to be continually evoked.

Although identity resources are continually used in the process of identity construction, often the different identity resources come into conflict or contradict each other because identity is multi-faceted. People do not maintain one identity in all circumstances at all times, because there are different resources to draw upon to address the specific roles people perform. For example, when a person enacts the identity of a parent they draw on different identity resources than they would as a businesswoman or as a sports fan. Therefore, the identity work differs depending on the circumstance and role of the person who is enacting the identity and what they are attempting to accomplish. The need to draw on different identity resources to engage in different identity work often causes a struggle with how people accomplish their identity. Thus, identity resources often conflict, creating contradictions in the continual construction of the person’s identity and how they ultimately view themselves. The internal conflict creates both positive (e.g., curiosity) and negative (e.g., anxiety) emotions but eventually the contradictions become too strong, leading to “a search for ways of actively dealing with identity” (Sveningsson & Alvesson, 2003, p. 1167).

An Identity Work Theory-based Model of Fan De-escalation

According to identity work theory, a sports fan is similar to a teacher, parent or spouse; it is an identity. And, as an identity, being a fan is a dynamic, ongoing process (Garfinkel, 1964, 1967). The process involves a fan feeling, speaking and acting in ways that identify the person as

a fan. However, just as some people remain lifelong fans, others lose connection to their favorite sport objects and no longer follow their teams, cheer for their favorite player, and/or wear the jersey. In other words, some sports fans are unable to continually accomplish their fan identity. In the sections below we propose a conceptual model based on identity work theory (See Figure 1) that explains the process of sport fan de-escalation. To help aid comprehension, the corresponding number or letter of each item in the model is provided in parentheses.

Maintaining fandom.

The model begins when a sports fan is still cheering for their team. Here the fan is maintaining their identity, and two factors work together to ensure the sports fan's identity endures and the fan continues their team support. The first is *cognitive and emotional escalation* (1) that occurs when there are emotional and cognitive connections between the sport fan and the sport object. For example, the brand loyalty literature suggests that loyal consumers have a strong, positive attitude towards a brand, and that cognitions and affect are antecedents to attitude (Dick & Basu, 1994). Also, Funk and James (2001) note an affective connection to a team or a player is part of the process whereby a fan moves up the PCM to allegiance. The emotional and psychological connection a fan has with the sport object cultivates a bond that is manifested in an alignment between the fan's personal values and the values personified by the sport object. When a fan is cognitively and emotionally connected to the sport object, there is an *alignment in fan values* (A). To maintain a fan identity, however, requires effort (e.g., Creed, Dejordy & Lok, 2011). The alignment of fan values is a significant component of a sport fan identity, but to continually accomplish this identity the fan must reinforce the alignment between their values and those of the sports object. Fans whose identity is tied to their connection to a team engage in the process of *reinforcing fan values* (3). The deeper the emotional and cognitive

connection between the sports fan and the sports object, the greater likelihood the fan identity will be maintained.

The second element of maintaining fandom is *material escalation* (2). While one element of sport fan identity is the affective, cognitive connection to the sport object, another aspect is the material side. There are a number of material practices that identify a person as a fan. This notion is congruent both with the brand identity literature that stipulates loyal consumers are those who repeatedly purchase the brand (Dick & Basu, 1994), and with the fan identification literature that suggests highly identified fans direct relatively high levels of behavior towards the team (Gladden & Funk, 2001). Painting one's face, yelling at a referee, discussing the game at the water cooler, and looking up player statistics, are all practices that physically embody fandom. Sports fans accomplish an identity when they act like sports fan. When fans act like a fan of a sports object they have *unimpeded access to fan practices* (B). The unencumbered access to the material practices of fandom does not ensure the sport fan identity endures. In keeping with identity work theory, we suggest the practices of fandom have to be continually evoked for fans to inhabit their identity. To do so, fans routinize the unimpeded material practices of a sports fan identity. Thus, for many it becomes taken-for-granted that they will watch games, cheer for their teams, and check box scores. The routines of fan behavior reinforce what it means to be a fan and reproduce the material practices that embody correct fan behaviors. *Routinizing fan practices* (4) is the second way sport fan identity is maintained.

In sum, when the cognitive/affective values are reinforced and the practical/material behaviors are routinized, sports fans are maintaining their identity. In addition, both sport fan values and the unimpeded access to fan practices feed into each other. Fan values will influence which material practices are most appropriate to routinize while different material practices will

help reinforce fan values. Consequently, when both the personal values and material practices of the sports fan are mutually reinforcing, the sports fan’s identity is accomplished and maintained.

Disrupting/repairing fandom.

The bonds that fan have with their sport objects change over time. As fans age and mature, they change jobs, enter new relationships and/or leave old ones. Similarly, a team’s roster, coaching staff and management will eventually be replaced. The consequence of this changing relationship is that the dynamic process of accomplishing a sport fan identity is complicated.

As a consequence of this complex process there is potential for fan value misalignment. This *misalignment of fan values* (5) occurs when there is a disconnect between what the sport object represents to the fan and what they feel it *should* represent. At this point, the cognitive and emotional connection between the fan and the sports object is disrupted, creating *cognitive and emotional conflict* (C) in the fan’s identity. The sports fan feels discomfort when personal values are incompatible with the values of the sport object and this discomfort needs to be quelled. Commonly in this situation, the sports fan repairs this breach by *re-aligning fan values* (7). For example, fans often reconcile the misbehavior of favorite players. Although some will stop cheering, many fans will find ways to justify their continued connection with a player despite their questionable behaviors. The fan will expend effort to ensure that their values as a sport fan and the sports object (e.g., unethical player) align. These actions repair the breach within the fan values and their identity as a sports fan is reinforced.

As noted above, there are numerous material practices that people can and do draw on to describe themselves as sports fans. But, like the cognitive connection fans have with the sport object, these material practices may also change.

A sports fan is, at times, unable to engage in the practices that contribute to their identity. The accomplishment of fan practices can be interrupted by significant life changes such as taking a job in a new city or starting a new relationship, or rather trivial life changes, like a broken television or a visit from the in-laws. Regardless, when sports fans face *barriers to fan practices* (6) this leads to *practical impediments* (D) that prevent the material accomplishment of their fan identity.

This situation parallels the cognitive conflict sports fans feel when their fan values are misaligned. Practical impediments prevent fans from accomplishing their identity because they are unable to act like fans. To repair this situation the fan will attempt to minimize or eliminate this disruption by *removing barriers to fan practices* (8). In so doing, the sports fan's identity is reaffirmed because the material encumbrances that prevented fan activity are removed. As an outcome, the fan is freely able to continue routinizing fan practices, which maintains the sport fan identity.

While either cognitive conflict or practical impediments can be enough to lead to de-escalation (as will be explained in the following section), the two need not be mutually-exclusive. In many cases, fans will experience the two simultaneously. Hence, the broken arrow between them in our model.

De-escalation.

A sports fan's identity is relatively resilient. When faced with challenges to accomplishing their identity sports fans can, and often do, find different cognitive/emotional and practical solutions. That said, there are times where the fan is unable to accomplish their identity and it wanes and dissolves. It is at this stage when sports fans de-escalate their commitment and stop cheering for their teams.

A sports fan feels anxious when there is conflict between their values and the perceived values of the sport object. *Cognitive and emotional de-escalation* (9) occurs when a sports fan cannot repair this conflict. The accomplishment of the sport fan identity is no longer tenable because fan values cannot be re-aligned. The sports object, sports fan or both have changed. Now the conflict between what the fan now values and what the team appears to value is incommensurate. When a fan's cognitive and emotional conflict is irreconcilable, they stop cheering and become non-fans.

Non-fandom, however, is not just another static identity. This new identity is also an accomplished effort. A non-fan identity requires effort to ensure that the perceived cognitive and emotional conflict continues and endures. This occurs by *enhancing cognitive and emotional conflict* (11). Therefore, not only is it imperative to identify the conflict in values, but this conflict also needs to be continually reinforced for the non-fan to accomplish their new identity. If this conflict is not emphasized, it is highly probable that cognitive de-escalation will not persist. It is only when the perceived cognitive conflict is actively enhanced that the new non-fan identity is fully inhabited.

Similarly, *material de-escalation* (10) occurs when the practical impediments to fan practices are not repaired. The barriers to sports fan behaviors remain, preventing the fan from enacting the routinized behaviors. The result is material de-escalation and the embrace of a non-fan identity. However, for a sports fan to become a non-fan, the practical impediments need to remain salient. A non-fan finds ways of *embedding practical impediments* (12) into their behaviors and actions. The non-fan fills their time with activities that do not lead to the routinizing of fan practices. As the practical impediments become firmly embedded in the

activities of the non-fan, material de-escalation is strengthened. The result is the solidification of the new, non-fan identity.

In our study, when we speak of solidifying a new, non-fan identity, we are not necessarily saying they are no longer fans of sports or sports teams; they are non-fans with respect to their former favorite NHL team. The new identities now embraced may indeed be sport-related, such as becoming a soccer fan instead of a hockey fan.

To both come to an understanding of the process of fandom disruption and de-escalation, and to test the model, we studied 23 former fans of NHL teams. Our primary research question was: Why do fans of an NHL team stop following that team and become people who are no longer fans of any NHL team? The use of interpretive interviews presented an opportunity to understand both their current relationship with the sport of hockey, and whether or not they thought they could become NHL team fans again in the future. Consequently, our secondary research questions were: What place has the sport of hockey had in their lives since the team fandom ended?”, and: “Could they become fans of NHL teams in the future?”

Method

The goal of this research project was to advance the knowledge base within the specific field of sport management where scholars attempt to understand the thoughts, feelings, and behaviors of sport fans in general (and in our case, former fans specifically). It is not our intent to solve current problems industry practitioners may be experiencing, so our research should be seen as basic research concerned with theory generation in the consumer behaviorist tradition of Morris Holbrook, instead of applied research in the marketing tradition where solutions are found to real-world problems (Holbrook, 1987).

We assumed the process of fans severing ties to their favorite NHL team would be contextually rich. As such, this research is situated within the interpretive paradigm, which is suitable when research questions involve understanding potentially complex phenomena framed within the context of individual actors creating and interpreting their social world (Amis, 2005; Neuman, 2006). It is common for interpretive researchers to use such qualitative methods as long interviews whereby the people who have lived through the phenomenon under investigation can tell their stories in their own words in ways that make sense to them (Amis, 2005; Denzin, 1989).

While we could have conducted this research using former fans of teams in different sports and leagues, we studied former NHL team fans for two reasons. First, both of us are based in Canada, where the NHL is the most popular sports league. We assumed the league with the largest fan base might mathematically produce the largest pool of former fans amongst the sporting options available to study. Thus sampling might be easier with an NHL focus versus another league. Second, we have followed the NHL for decades, resulting in a knowledge base that would help us better understand the context of the stories we heard. This NHL-centric knowledge proved useful for two reasons. First, it built rapport with the participants who quickly surmised we were not outsiders to the world of NHL fandom. This rapport helped encourage the telling of stories with rich, thick description- a strength of interpretive research (Schwartz & Jacobs, 1979). Second, it became a trustworthiness strategy. If we heard a story with factual inaccuracies, we asked probing follow-up questions to ascertain if it was a slip of the tongue, or an indication the participant did not meet the participation criteria.

Research Design

Twenty-four people were interviewed to find our sample of 23 former fans of NHL teams who no longer cheer for any NHL team. They were interviewed face-to-face and one-on-one

between May 2011 and February 2013. Data collection ended then as we reached the point of theoretical saturation (where each new interview reveals less and less relevant new insight and merely adds support to existing themes) (Strauss & Corbin, 1998). The sample consisted of 20 men and three women, aged 18-67 (with an average age of 43). Pseudonyms were assigned to help protect confidentiality (see Appendix A for participant profiles). We recruited using a combination of electronic postings, paper flyers on public bulletin boards, word-of-mouth, and news media exposure. Due to geographic constraints, four interviews were conducted using Skype video conferencing software, while the other 20 were in-person. During the interview, the 23 participants in our sample gave evidence they were once either in the attachment or allegiance stage of the PCM with respect to their former favorite team, yet no longer consider themselves fans of any NHL team. The person providing the 24th interview did not tell a story indicating he once had a strong attachment to a team. Instead, he had an attraction to star players throughout the NHL. As he did not meet our criteria, he was removed from our sample.

Data Collection

Prior to the interview, participants gave informed consent and completed a short demographic questionnaire. To encourage them to tell their stories in their own words, the interviews were semi-structured using an interview protocol containing open-ended questions. As the fan experience would be part of an ongoing process dating back to each person's earliest hockey experiences, the protocol had questions regarding how each became a fan, what it was like to be a fan, the process involved with the breaking of the team-fan bond, the meaning of the sport of hockey today, and what the future may hold. As these were semi-structured interviews, participants were asked unscripted, probing, follow-up questions as interesting points emerged. Interviews ranged from 19 to 59 minutes (35 minutes being the average). Each was audio

recorded and transcribed verbatim, producing 246 single-spaced pages of transcript. Participants were sent copies of their transcripts and asked to check for inaccuracies. Fourteen responded to this member check, with most confirming the transcript’s accuracy. The few requesting changes asked for minor edits, which were made before those transcripts were coded.

Data Analysis

Data collection, coding, and analysis were concurrent. Each interview was transcribed soon after completion, and coded soon after the member check concluded. Initially, codes were taken from the fan identity de-escalation literature (Smith et al., 1981; Wann et al., 1996). As two researchers both interviewed and coded, a codebook was developed containing conceptual definitions for each code, as well as examples of when to code (and not to code) based on each definition (MacQueen, McLellan-Lemal, Bartholow, & Milstein, 2008). As interviewing progressed, new codes were added (and the codebook updated accordingly) as new themes emerged as we constantly compared the newest data to the previously collected data. At this point, previous transcripts were recoded so the latest codes could be added to previous ones. This iterative process of constant comparison continued until the final interview was coded. As part of this process, the researchers were in regular communication to discuss the ongoing coding and analysis. Eventually, consensus was reached regarding the identification of the interesting insights emerging from the interviews. These insights are reported below.

Findings

The reasons given to explain how and why a fan of an NHL hockey team could become a non-fan can be grouped into seven broader themes: disillusionment with certain aspects of sport, disillusionment with the sport of hockey, issues at the NHL level, team-related characteristics

now perceived as off-putting, individual players, the media, and various other outside influences we call “life.” (See Appendix B for the reasons given by each participant.) Some former fans gave a single reason and told a straight-forward story, with a few pointing to a single incident (e.g., the NHL Lockout cancelling the 2004-05 season). Others told of a multi-faceted process of various inter-related factors that lead to the de-escalation of team identification over time. In one case, the participant told a story that stretched over 30 years. We also found the former fans could typically be grouped into three age-based cohorts, where participants in each cohort told similar stories. As for their current feelings towards hockey, we found much support for national teams playing in international competition. We also found two people who used to cheer for their local “small-market” team who want the team to remain a vibrant part of the city for the sake of the overall community psyche, even though neither no longer cares if the team wins or loses on a game-by-game basis. As for participants’ guesses for the future, the most interesting insight was the speculation their children or grandchildren may socialize them into cheering for teams some years from now.

Aside from the three research questions, the findings will be used to test the last two stages of the model (disrupting fandom and de-escalation). The seven themes are addressed below, along with how each relates to the model. To help the reader better cross-reference the findings with the model, the corresponding number or letter of each item in the model will be provided in parentheses.

The Seven Themes Explaining the De-escalation

Theme #1- Becoming disillusioned with certain aspects of sport.

NHL team fandom is nested within the world of sport. If fans begin to critically question that world, their fandom may be affected. During the NHL Lockout of 2004-05, Max concluded

North American major league sport was over-commercialized. He soon lost interest in it in general, partially explaining why he is no longer a Montreal Canadiens fan. He did, however, continue to support his favorite European soccer team and does so to this day. After years of supporting the Edmonton Oilers, Kurt questioned why he was living and dying with the fortunes of a professional team. He concluded it was all only a game and explained, “...I think that’s part of the reason that I pulled away, because I don’t want to identify so much with something that I feel is not real.” Jim’s disillusionment reaches deeper than simply North American professional sport. As a teacher, he is frustrated that schools have money for sports, but not necessarily academics. This leads him to state that spectator sport has gotten too big in our society, and he no longer sees it as something to lose sleep over:

We (his high school) are in the middle of budget issues, and they are so worried about the God-damned football program. Like, it’s an extra-curricular activity! You’re going to cut classroom stuff so that these kids can have money to play sports? I believe in a well-rounded education. I’m a huge fan of liberal arts. I’m a huge fan of experience. I think athletics is part of it, but it’s not more important. It’s *part* of the puzzle. I think we’ve gotten to the point where it’s more important than it should be. (emphasis his)

Of course, it should not surprise that Jim not only no longer actively follows the Buffalo Sabres, but he also no longer follows the National Football League’s (NFL) Bills, Major League Baseball’s (MLB) Tigers, or Syracuse University basketball. He was once a committed fan of all of these teams.

In these three examples, we see a misalignment of values (5) with respect to our model. While at one point, the values surrounding certain aspects of sport were congruent with their personal values (A), an incongruence occurred over time. Max concluded that major league sport

become over-commercialized, Kurt could no longer value supporting something that “is not real,” and Jim realized that he should be supporting things that are much more important. This cognitive and emotional conflict (C) lead to de-escalation (9) in each case.

Theme #2- Becoming disillusioned with certain aspects of the sport of hockey.

Similar to the first theme, NHL team fandom is nested within the sport of hockey, so critically questioning the sport may impact fandom. Steve stopped being a Detroit Red Wings fan in high school soon after moving to a city hosting an Ontario Hockey League (OHL) team. As the OHL is one of Canada’s three elite Major Junior “A” leagues, the best OHL players commonly go on to NHL careers. As such, OHL players typically acquire celebrity status while still in high school. Steve saw a different side. Simultaneously, he started playing elite soccer, and the more he learned of soccer, the worse hockey looked:

Hockey took on a negative connotation for me throughout high school as I kind of got to experience some of these OHL kids in my school and the kind of treatment that they were afforded and the celebrity status that they were given and they were typically giant douchebags and the more I learned about hockey....I just did not like it. And so the whole hockey attitude, I just really changed my tone on it and I disidentified with the sport as a whole....The game itself, I didn’t enjoy watching. Maybe it was because I was *really* into soccer at that time. Played on a really good team. Soccer is this sport where sharing the ball and maintaining possession is *so* important, right?....A turn-over (in hockey) is not...a big deal like it would be in basketball- because I’m starting to watch basketball by this time as well- and soccer. You *value* possessions in those sports. But in hockey, to me, it just seemed like there was not enough emphasis on really good passing or keeping possession of the puck. (emphasis his)

While Steve discussed hockey’s culture in terms of the off-putting “hockey attitude” personified by elite junior players, others who became disillusioned with the sport discussed the

prevalence of fighting not just in the NHL, but also at so many levels of the sport. Fifty-two-year-old former Boston Bruins fan Ralph grew up playing hockey in Canada and accepted fighting as part of the game. As a middle-aged adult however, he found himself playing recreational rugby for the first time, and his experience changed his attitude towards fighting in particular and hockey overall:

...the very first time I touched the rugby ball, it was like I got hit by a car. And I got up and I thought, "Who do I punch in the head?" Because if that's a hockey game, you're punching somebody in the head. And then I realized, "Oh shit. It's rugby. I can't fight." And I thought, "What do I do? I'm just going to play." And at that moment, the switch went off and I realized that fighting in hockey is just a learned behavior. You're in a rink? You know it's ok to punch somebody in the head. Whereas the exact same action or worse, on a soccer field or rugby field or baseball field, you can't, so you don't. That mechanism isn't there....I actually think that turning around and starting a fight is the cowardly thing to do. You're way more of a man if you just take it and you just play through it.

With respect to our model, we again see examples of people who experienced a misalignment of fan values (5). Steve felt it was wrong to grant celebrity status to high school hockey players when he came to experience it first-hand, while Ralph came to feel that the sport should not accept fighting. This led to conflict (C), cognitive and emotional de-escalation (9), and the identity of a non-fan.

Theme #3- Issues at the NHL level.

NHL team fandom falls within the context of the league, so fans who begin to critically assess how the NHL is run and what it represents, may find the team-fan bond loosen. The vast majority of participants fit into this category. While many of them stopped being fans in the twentieth century, every single participant who still considered themselves fans heading into the

2004-05 Lockout had their fandom negatively impacted by the labor conflict. Of this group, Linda, Rodney, Bruce, and Andy said the greed of the players/owners soured them on NHL hockey, Reid, Billy, and Blake said that the new-found free time enabled them to find other pursuits during the Lockout and they never looked back afterward, and Max, Walt, and Dave said it was a combination of the two. In Walt’s case, he remembers thinking during the Lockout, “How could you do this? They make millions of dollars. Who cares? Just suck it up and play.” That same year, he entered high school and started playing football. With no hockey to watch, he began following the NFL and the National Basketball Association (NBA)- sports he paid little attention to previously as the Red Wings took up so much of his time and attention. By the time the NHL started play again the next winter, he had become a highly identified Eagles (NFL) and Raptors (NBA) fan, and had no time to reintroduce hockey into his fandom:

...the Lockout just completely ruined it for me. And I think also it might be because I was juggling. It would have been juggling three sports at a time afterwards. It was just too much information. Watching football, basketball, *and* hockey? Plus playing football and attending high school. I just ran out of time to actually care for everything. (emphasis his)

Of the others in this category, understanding their de-escalation is best accomplished by juxtaposing their stories with the NHL’s evolution beginning in 1967. In that year the league started rapidly expanding into new regions- growing from six to 18 teams by 1974. Susan said this made it too confusing to follow all the new teams and players, and both Carl and Cliff noted expansion watered-down the league’s talent pool resulting in mediocre hockey. With Rick, it was more than just confusion and mediocre hockey- it was greed. Rick, who became a Canadiens fan in his 1950s childhood, could not wrap his head around the cartoony team names, colors, and

logos found in the new NHL. To him, it destroyed the essence of a league that now seemed more about marketing and profits than hockey:

When the league expanded from six to twelve, and you started getting names like *Penguins* as a team, as opposed to Canadiens or Maple Leafs, and you’d get the funny different sounding names, funny colored jerseys. The teams were watered down at that time. And then when they went from twelve to- I think eighteen?...I didn’t realize it was a money thing then, but in retrospect probably thought, “This game is going to pot.” The gamesmanship, the style of hockey changed drastically then. And I think what I liked about the game or what I appreciated about the game and what I felt about the game, that changed with the expansion of the league twice in a short period of time. And they went to cities that didn’t even have snow. It was like, “You know what? Why am I even bothering?” (emphasis his)

While the effects of expansion seemed to dominate league-related reasons for de-escalation in the 1970s, fans said the 1988 trade of Edmonton’s Wayne Gretzky to Los Angeles impacted their fandom. Both Jerry and Carl mentioned the trading of the Canadian hockey icon from a small-market Canadian city to a huge American market made them realize the league was less about hockey and hockey fans and more about money. As Jerry tells it, “...when Gretzky got traded, I was getting old enough to realize, ‘Ok, this isn’t a game. This is a business.’ They are going to make money whatever way they can.” Both men (as well as Ralph, Jim, and Rodney) also noted that into the 1990s, the league’s style of play changed from the free-wheeling offence-oriented style personified by Gretzky and the 1980s Oilers, to a much less-exciting one where teams with less-skilled players would “clutch and grab” skilled players, or employ defensive-oriented “systems” such as “the trap”, to gain an edge. Of those who mentioned their frustration with the NHL’s defensive-style of play in the 1990s, only Rodney’s team fandom survived the decade, only to be killed by the Lockout as noted above.

Once again, we see a misalignment of values (5)- this time at the league level. Living through the experience of expansion changing the league for the worse, or now seeing the league as greedy- first personified by the Gretzky trade and later by the Lockout- we see cognitive and emotional conflict (C) and de-escalation (9). However, we now see examples of barriers to fan practices (6) leading to practical impediments (D), as we heard stories of how fans were unable to watch their teams play during the Lockout. Walt’s story is an example of both cognitive and emotional conflict (C) and practical impediments (D) simultaneously disrupting his fandom, as he was first disgusted by the players’ greed (“Just suck it up and play.”), then struggled with time management in high school when the NHL finally resumed play (“I just ran out of time.”). With both cognitive/emotional (9) and material de-escalation (10), he became a non-fan of the Red Wings.

Theme #4- Team-related characteristics now perceived as off-putting.

Participants also cited issues at the team level as contributing to their waning interest. While many cited perceived organizational mismanagement, one cited issues with the team’s home market and local fan base. Blake had cheered for the Dallas Stars throughout his boyhood in small-town Ontario. As he aged and learned more about the context of the team, he concluded the average Dallas sports fan did not share his passion for the club. He surmised that, “Hockey was just another thing down in Dallas. And that’s kind of, ‘Well, why am I rooting for them a continent away?’” Soon after, he found other teams in other sports to follow during the Lockout, and he has not looked back.

The others citing team-related characteristics told stories of feeling that the team’s management had alienated them somehow, such as with too much emphasis on making money over winning, or a feeling the team treated its fans poorly. Ralph had followed the Boston Bruins

from afar for decades, and he gradually came to see the team as caring more about profit maximization than winning:

I began to realize that their business plan was to always have a couple of players that were stars that would keep them competitive and keep the fans interested. Because fans like following stars. But they never gave them the supporting cast, because that would cost money...And they knew that they would never win. Like, I always assumed from the outside that they were trying every year to win, but when I got close, I realized that, “No. This is the way they do things. It’s not about winning. It’s just about maximizing profit.”

Later in the interview, Ralph said the “last nail in the coffin” came in 2005 when the team traded captain Joe Thornton for lesser players- a move Ralph claims confirmed that the Bruins were all about profit and not about winning. He thought at the time, “they just don’t deserve *any* fans.” (emphasis his)

Many former Maple Leafs fans echoed Ralph’s reasoning with respect to the Leafs, as typified by Cliff (“...run very unprofessionally...”), Ray (“I’m still mad at them for being so pathetic- the management of the organization.”), and Reid (“...they were making no effort to make their team better. And at that point I said, ‘Why should I support a team that doesn’t seem like they believe in the interests of the fans?’”). It must be noted they were not upset with the losing per se, but upset that management seemed to have no interest in winning. They understood the Bruins and Leafs to have the resources to win, but thought they were unwilling to use them. In fact, only one participant (Lisa) cited her team’s (Maple Leafs) losing as a stand-alone reason for de-escalation, and she explained it was a minor one in comparison to her growing distaste of hockey’s violent culture, the media, and the Leafs making fighter Tie Domi the face of the franchise. This is interesting, given previous research has suggested losing is a major factor in

fandom cessation (Wann et al., 1996). In this light, Steve’s story fascinates, as one reason he gave for ending his Red Wings fandom was their mid-90s back-to-back Stanley Cup championships producing “all these bandwagon fans”, and as he had been loyal for years, he distanced himself from them (in part) so as not to be perceived as a fair-weather fan. Consequently, we found as many people who cited winning as a reason for their de-escalation as cited losing.

In this section, we see more examples of the mis-alignment of values (5), in many cases, the realization that the favorite team put their greedy self-interest ahead of both the fans’ concerns for fair treatment and the fans’ desire to win championships. The case of Blake mirrors that of Walt (noted above) in that his mis-alignment of values (5) (his questioning why he should cheer for a team from afar once he realized the locals in Dallas seemed to lack his passion for the Stars) happened concurrently with a barrier to fan practices (6) (having no NHL hockey to watch during the Lockout). Both cognitive/emotional (9) and material de-escalation (10) resulted.

Theme #5- Individual players.

Participants also noted individual players as contributing to their fandom’s end. It may have been a strong attachment to a specific player that, upon retirement or trade, resulted in less attachment to the team (former Canadiens fan Bruce said Jean Beliveau’s retirement started his de-escalation). It may also have been a sense of betrayal felt when a player is perceived to misbehave in such a way as to cause fans to question their fandom. Please note, if participants expressed disgust at NHL players in general (e.g., seen as greedy during the Lockout), those sentiments were coded under “league.”

Former Ottawa Senators fan Linda was not only turned-off by the NHL players’ perceived greed during the 2004-05 Lockout, but also by the lack of team loyalty displayed by

star Senator Zdeno Chara one year later. She recalled that the small-market Senators would be unable to sign both their star free agents for market value following the 2005-06 season. As many Ottawa fans believed, the team was trying to get both Chara and Wade Redden (his defensive blue line partner) to take less pay so both could be re-signed, leaving them strong Stanley Cup contenders. The plan backfired:

...when Wade Redden was negotiating his contract, he agreed to take less money than he was demanding, so that that would free-up money in the Sens' salary budget to be able to pay Chara to keep him. And then Chara bolted for Boston? Without even going back to the Sens and saying, "Hey, what are you going to offer me?" So Wade Redden was then screwed, because he's stuck in Ottawa without his linemate and without a real possibility of getting the Cup. *And* he took a pay cut. Well, of course Redden didn't stick around for very long....So it was the Lockout that made me jaded towards NHL players in general, and then it was the Chara bolting, and then I realized, "You know what? He didn't give a rat's behind about the Senators. He only wanted to win the Stanley Cup and he thought that with the Bruins he had a better chance." So that's when I kind of pulled back and said, "Whoa. Whoa. Ok, I need to have other priorities now." (emphasis hers)

Linda experienced mutually-reinforcing cognitive and emotional conflict (C) based on value mis-alignment (5). Not only did she come to see the NHL's locked-out players as greedy, but she also grew to see one of her own team's stars behaving in a way she could not condone, as she felt Chara "screwed" Redden. This led to cognitive and emotional de-escalation (9) and a non-fan identity.

Theme #6- The media.

The media was cited as a contributing factor by former fans. Susan and Lisa were upset at how the television media covering the NHL glorified fighting by enthusiastically showing and

replaying flights, while Jim and Cliff felt that with so much sports now on television (including hockey), games are less special, leading to waning interest due to overexposure. Former Oilers fan Kurt noted that in small-market Edmonton, he perceived the local media as being too cozy with the team. They became organizational mouth-pieces instead of impartial journalists, leading to a feeling of betrayal. Finally, former Maple Leafs' fan Royce said it was the narrative surrounding the Leafs games (and NHL overall) that got him interested in the team and league; it taught him about the players' personalities. Yet after some years he noticed the storylines became repetitive. The media narrative was old, stale, and predictable. That is when he lost interest:

I'm (no longer) interested in the narrative behind it. Especially the journalism that fills in this space in this season. To say, "Oh there's a story, this is a super comeback or this guy's a warrior, he's the blah, blah, blah." I was watching a game one or two weeks ago with my friends- I was at their house and they're watching the game- and we started mocking the "Shit Sportscasters Say". Because they're so predictable...One of the reasons why I stopped being interested in the narratives presented around hockey seasons and teams is the feeling that I have seen it all before...that lack of originality may be a contributing factor in why I stopped being a fan.

Royce also mentioned travelling to Europe twice in his late teens. Each trip coincided with the Stanley Cup playoffs. At first, he sought NHL news, but found very little. As he was having such a great travel experience overall however, he soon began to question the importance of his fandom. He realized he did not miss it and became less interested in the NHL and the Leafs- a disinterest that continued on his return home. Many others mentioned that the weakening of the team-fan bond came about in part by a change in their situation that lead either

to barriers making it more difficult to continue fandom, or to an opening-up of new possibilities for their time and attention, as will be discussed below.

When examining the stories coded “media”, we see both people turned-off because they felt the media was doing something it should not do (e.g. glorify fighting, make sport less special due to over-exposure), and a person who not only felt his values mis-aligned (5) with what he saw in the sports media, but also experienced a barrier to fan practice (6) (the lack of NHL-related media coverage in Europe). Royce’s story fits our model in a third way. His might be the best example of actively maintaining a non-fan identity through enhancing cognitive and emotional conflict (11), as he sat down with his hockey fan friends to mock the things sportscasters say, reaffirming his non-fan identity.

Theme #7- Life.

People’s situations change. Many participants said changing life contexts were responsible (in whole or in part) for de-escalation. Susan was a huge Maple Leafs fan as a child and young adult in the 1950s and 60s, but married and moved to a region of Canada with few Leaf fans. Her husband stopped being a hockey fan in the mid-70s (he was turned-off by the tactical use of violence then common), so as she said, “consequently if he’s watching something else- we’re a one TV family- I’m not going to be (watching the Leafs).” They raised a family in the 1970s and 80s, and looking back she said, “It (her de-escalation) may have had a lot to do, as well, with me raising a family and being busy.” In the 1980s and into the 90s, the two spent winters in various non-hockey social pursuits, then in the mid-90s, began spending winters in semi-retirement in the American deep south, where “hockey is not a huge thing.” Eventually, with lessening exposure to the NHL and the Leafs, surrounded all winter by people caring little for hockey, she realized she too no longer cared. The process took three decades.

In many cases coded “life”, participants said at a certain point they were merely exposed to various other leisure activities (often sporting) and found themselves with the time and opportunity to pursue them, as Walt said above. For example, during the Lockout, Dave discovered European soccer and regularly travels to Europe to watch big matches, both Toronto-based Billy and Reid began actively following one or both of the two other local big-league teams (NBA’s Raptors and MLB’s Blue Jays) and eventually transferred their passionate fandom to them, and Max began playing basketball competitively- a sport that held his attention post-Lockout. Over time, these people came to realize their new pursuits took on enough importance to supersede their (now former) favorite NHL team. In many cases, this process was coded both “life” and “league”, as many who were fans going into the 2004 season-cancelling Lockout found themselves with unexpected free-time caused by the lack of NHL hockey to watch. They filled this free time with other pursuits, and continued with the new pursuits once the NHL resumed play in the fall of 2005. They were only exposed to these new outside influences (“life”) because there was no hockey to watch (“league”). As it had been from six to eight years between the end of the Lockout and the time of each interview, it appears the pursuits that usurped NHL hockey fandom cannot be considered short-term fads in the lives of these former fans.

The stories told by Dave, Billy, Reid, and Max are examples of maintaining identities as people who are not fans of NHL teams. In these four cases, they have embedded practical impediments (12) that would keep them from rekindling their former fandom. They have all replaced the activities they used to do that routinized their NHL team fandom with other activities having to do with their new identities (as soccer fan, Raptors fan, Jays fan, and basketball player).

Aged-Based Cohorts

In an attempt to answer our first research question, we not only found seven reasons why the team-fan bond ended, but we also grouped many of our participants into three age-based cohorts. We will discuss these cohorts before turning our attention to our remaining two research questions.

It makes sense to find that 18 of the 23 participants can be categorized into age-based cohorts who told similar stories when explaining their identification de-escalation. For example, fans who stopped being fans in the twentieth century will not suggest that the 2004-05 Lockout had an impact, because they had long stopped being fans by then. Consequently, people in their 20s who became fans in the 1990s will not list the sea-change in the NHL's structure in the late-1960s and early-70s as a reason, as they would not know to compare the “modern” NHL to a bygone era never experienced.

“Younger” people emphasizing the Lockout. Eight participants (Max, 20; Reid, 21; Walt 21; Billy 20; Linda, 44; Rodney, 38; Blake, 18; Dave, 58- average age, 30) pointed to the Lockout as a very major reason for the severing of the team-fan bond. It either involved outrage at the greedy owners and players, or simply finding other things to do with their newfound free time they continued to pursue post-Lockout, or a combination of both. This includes five of the six in their teens and 20s.

“Middle-aged” people turned-off by violence. Six participants (Jerry, 46; Ralph, 52; Ray, 61; Lisa, 36; Jim, 46; Bruce, 50- average age, 49) said that over time they began to question the violent culture of either the NHL or hockey in general, typically suggesting either the culture changed for the worse, or they themselves changed and began to question the culture they used to accept. They often mentioned fighting, “clutching and grabbing”, and various assorted

“goonery” they could no longer stomach. In many cases, they became fans in the 1960s and 1970s, and cheered for teams now having legendary reputations for highly-skilled beautiful play. Of the cohort’s three parents (Jerry, Ray, and Lisa), all struggled to reconcile their roles as parents trying to find healthy, sporting, leisure pursuits for their children, and their distaste for a sport now seen as potentially violent and unhealthy.

“Older” people who cited league expansion. Four (Susan, 66; Rick, 58; Cliff, 62; Carl, 59- average age, 61) of the seven participants who became fans pre-1967(during the “Original Six” teams era), cited expansion as a de-escalation factor. They mentioned the quality of play dropped, hockey was now played in warm-climates where it should not be, and the intimacy of knowing every player on all six teams was replaced by watching unknown players on unknown teams. While expansion was not the only reason given (or even necessarily the most significant one), the four listed it as a factor.

The Sport of Hockey in their Lives Now

Our second research question involved understanding what place the sport of hockey has had in their lives since their NHL team fandom ended. Answers ranged from complete disinterest in hockey (Steve), to simply turning-off NHL hockey but remaining committed to playing hockey recreationally (Jerry and Carl) and/or closely following local amateur junior leagues or professional minor leagues (Carl and Bruce). The two most interesting themes involved supporting national teams, and caring for the local team not from a fan’s perspective, but from seeing the team as a civic institution.

National team support. The majority of former fans mentioned they will watch their national teams play in international competition. As Edward explained, “Hockey to me only exists when...the Canadian maple leaf is on someone’s jersey.” In Canada, the annual World

Junior Championship (WJC) (held between Christmas and New Year's) receives a tremendous amount of coverage, and all of the Canadian team's games are broadcast live. For fans like Rodney (turned-off of the NHL because of perceived greed), the WJC's teenaged amateurs are a perfect fit for those who still love the game:

...those guys are going out there and playing for something that means something to them. They're not doing it for money....They are doing it for the love of their country and the love of the sport. And at the expense that they might get a career-ending injury playing for their country. You know, it just means so much more when you see that red and white jersey.

Fans turned-off by the violence of hockey often embraced not only the WJC, but also watching the NHL players compete for their country in the Olympics, because of the perception that speed and skill are the focus. As Bruce bluntly suggests, “When you get the Olympics, or European-style hockey- skating first. You know what I mean? And the goon shit's left behind. Right?”

Edward's and Rodney's stories are interesting when juxtaposed with identity work theory, that states one must continuously adjust thoughts, feelings, and behaviors as one moves between identities. While both are former NHL team fans, their identity as patriotic Canadians pulls them back into hockey fandom when team Canada plays. Once these competitions end, other identities are reinforced.

The institution of the hometown team. While neither Kurt nor Jim care about the game-to-game results of the Oilers or Sabres anymore, both expressed an understanding of the team as a civic institution. Jim mentioned it would be “good for the city” if either the Sabres or Bills ever “brought a championship to Buffalo”, although he personally is “not going to lose sleep over it.”

Kurt echoes Jim's notion that a championship would be good for the city of Edmonton by stating that:

...you can feel it when the team's doing well. There's an energy and people buy into it, people believe it...There are some great cities that sort of transcend sports teams, like New York or whatever, but for a smaller city like Edmonton-how is this city identified? It's the sports teams, it's got to be, and hockey is number one.

When asked to explain the apparent contradiction of simultaneously not caring about the team (he is a non-fan after all), and caring about the team, Kurt gets a bit more philosophical:

I think it's kind of a spiritual thing, and I'm a non-believer, but I can still see the value in the spirituality, you know? I don't have that set of beliefs but I appreciate that it's important for a placeeven though I couldn't tell you who the first line is for the Oilers.

Here we again see two fans whose non-fan identities influence how they perceive a sports object. While neither now follows the Sabres or Oilers, both have strong identities as hometown supporters. As such, their identities as civic boosters result in hopes that the teams stay in their hometowns and achieve success there, to boost the collective psyche of the city.

Could They Ever Become NHL Team Fans Again?

Our final research question asked whether or not the participants could ever become NHL team fans again, and their answers revealed many examples of re-aligning fan values (7) or removing barriers to fan practices (8). While some left the door open to become team fans again (e.g., Reid, if he settles in an NHL city where team management respects the fans; Linda, maybe when she retires and has more time), and a few said emphatically they would never become fans again (Max, Steve, Rick, and Rodney), many said they could not see themselves ever cheering

for a team again unless some very drastic changes were made to the league, as the following answers to the question attest:

- (Bruce) Shorten the season. *Really* shorten the amount of teams that make the playoffs, and bring the best-of-seven (playoff series) down to one game. Then you’d see me go to the games, watch the games, yeah. And I bet you a lot more people would watch too.
(emphasis his)
- (Royce) I cannot foresee it. I simply don’t- (pauses). Maybe if something- you know what? No. If something really, really, really, radical happens, I might get curious. If they went back to six teams? (Both men laugh.) Something *crazy* like that, I might get curious.
(emphasis his)
- (Jerry) If you turned NHL into four-on-four (instead of the five skaters-on-five skaters used in regulation time) and eliminated set-up fighting, I’d probably watch...

Of course, few of these people are the least bit optimistic they will ever see these changes implemented, because they see their own suggestions primarily as fantasies. Realistically, they did not foresee themselves ever cheering for an NHL team again.

A further theme emerged from some participants’ answers to this question. Lisa and Edward were parents of young children, Susan was a grandparent of young grandchildren, and Royce was a 33-year-old single man considering his future as a potential parent. They speculated their kids/grandkids/future kids might draw them back in to team fandom if these children became fans of NHL teams. They believed in order to relate to or spend time with the kids/grandkids, you would start cheering for the same team. Re-developing a team-fan bond would become a strategy to strengthen the (grand)parent-child bond. Edward (father of a two-year-old son) when asked the question, replied:

I think so. Especially with my son, if he gets into the game.... I still want to be part of my son's life. So if he's interested in something, I would at least want to be interested enough so that I can have a conversation with him. And like, "Oh, who'd you go see?" 'Oh, the Maple Leafs are playing so-and-so.' "Oh, is such-and-such still on the team? How many points? Who's the leading scorer?" Or whatever- you can have a conversation. I wouldn't want to be like, "Oh good. Did you have a good time?" 'Yeah.' And that would be it. I'd want to try to contribute.

Here we have examples of speculating that in the future, these non-fans might rekindle NHL team fandom by re-aligning their values (7) so as to once again become fans. In keeping with identity work theory, we can see that they speculate that their identities as parents/grandparents might be strong enough that they will down-play their current cognitive and emotional conflict (C) and become fans of NHL teams once again, in order to participate in the thoughts, feelings, and behaviors they see as being extremely important to their (grand)parental identities.

Discussion

Based on our findings, we not only generated answers to our three research questions, but we also tested a model explaining the process of sport fan de-escalation. The answers given to the first research question resulted in seven themes that were indicative of either a misalignment of fan values (5) or barriers to fan practices (6). The answers given relative to the other two research questions revealed how identity work theory proves helpful in understanding how complicated the fandom process can be with respect to such competing identities as patriotic citizen and good parent. These findings help fill the void in the sport consumer behavior literature where scholars have called for a better understanding of fandom de-escalation (Funk &

James, 2001; Mullin et al., 2007). A more-detailed discussion of the findings with respect to relevant scholarly work is provided below.

Team Identification as a Multi-faceted Concept

Sport consumer behavior research typically takes as its unit of analysis fans of teams. However, as outlined previously, teams consist of a package of points of attachment or brand associations, such as the coach, players, venue, or logo, or with the sport played or the city represented (e.g., Gladden & Funk, 2001). Our findings that NHL team fandom is not only nested within sports in general, the sport of hockey itself, and the NHL specifically, but also is linked to the team’s players and the media that reports on it, lends support to the idea that team identification is a multi-faceted concept.

Re-examining Previous De-escalation Research

Smith et al. (1981) found that of the deeply committed sports fans they studied, a few speculated their interest might diminish because of greedy players, mounting legal issues, or a major change in their family commitments. Our former fans cited these reasons, plus many more. This may be partly explained by Smith et al.’s asking current deeply committed fans to speculate on a hypothetical. It may be akin to asking married people deeply in love to speculate on what may cause a future divorce. Happily married people committed to each other would be challenged to list all the potential causes of a break-up. However, we imagine divorced people would be able to not only identify the reasons for the break-up, but also to put them into the context of their lived experience, resulting in the nuanced understandings we found. Wann et al. (1996) studied people who no longer followed a former favorite team. The top five reasons were that the team was no longer successful, they developed other commitments or had a lack of time,

the loss of certain players, geographical reasons, and that friends and peers no longer followed the team. Our participants cited all four of the later reasons, but as noted above, success was typically mentioned not as a stand-alone reason, but as a symptom of a larger issue- greedy or incompetent team management. This difference may be explained by noting Wann et al. used pencil and paper surveys, and our long interviews may have provided more context around team success. As well, while their study’s participants stopped liking a former favorite team, the possibility existed they merely switched loyalties to a more successful team in the same league. In our case, all of our participants ended their NHL team fandom entirely, suggesting team success was one of many reasons why the team-fan bond ended. As seen in Appendix B, all who cited team-based reasons cited one to four other reasons as to how fandom ended. As well, Wann et al. surveyed undergraduate students, and it might be a case where young adults may be more likely than older adults to drop a team for merely success reasons. If, for example, the young are more likely than the old to have high levels of the personality trait self-monitoring, this might explain the phenomenon, as Mahony et al. (1999), found undergraduates who were high self-monitors more likely than low self-monitors to switch loyalties from a losing NFL team to a winning one.

Civic Versus Symbolic Allegiance

The stories told by Kurt and Jim suggested that even though our research participants no longer cared about the day-to-day fortunes of their local NHL team, they can still see the team’s importance as a civic institution. Their words are interesting when considering Lewis’ (2001) work. In his study of fans left behind by franchise relocation, he postulated team loyalty could focus on either civic or symbolic elements. Civic allegiance manifests itself when team identification is highly related to a strong identification with the team’s host city, typically found

in home-town fans. Symbolic allegiance describes loyalty to team-related characteristics, such as the team's name/colors/logo, more commonly found with out-of-town fans. In our research, we found civic allegiance living on long after fans stop being fans. While only two of the 23 expressed lingering civic allegiance, we must remember both continue to live in the same “small market” city home to their former favorite team. Considering all but one of the remaining former fans supported large-market teams where franchise relocation possibilities are remote, or cheered for small-market teams from afar, having two of these three mention continuing elements of civic allegiance is an interesting finding.

Parenting

One of the more interesting findings that resulted from asking if they could ever become NHL team fans again is that four of the 23 suggested their children/grandchildren/future children might rekindle their fandom should the children become NHL fans themselves. Much research into the formation of team identification notes how common it is for parents to socialize their children into becoming fans of the parents' favorite team (Kolbe & James, 2000; Wann, 2006). While there is some suggestion in previous research supporting the idea that children might be able to socialize parents into becoming fans (Hyatt, 2007), this “reverse socialization” remains underdeveloped in the fan literature.

Brand Loyalty

Our model suggests that the seven causes of de-escalation can be grouped into two categories: a misalignment of values (5), or barriers to fan practices (6). These findings are not incongruent with brand loyalty theory. Regarding the misalignment of values (5), the literature suggests brand loyalty can be negatively affected by a drop in brand trust (Chaudhuri &

Holbrook, 2001). An example of a specific management action that can lead to a drop in brand trust is the perception that the company behind the brand is acting unethically (Singh, Iglesias, & Batista-Foguet, 2012). Unethical behavior would be seen as an affront to the values held by loyal consumers, who would then question whether or not they should trust the company behind the brand, leading some to cease consuming it, thus ending the loyalty. With our former fans, we heard stories indicating a misalignment of values that can be framed in terms of previously loyal brand consumers no longer trusting either the companies behind their favorite brand (the NHL, or the team’s management) and/or the various brand associations or points of attachment (the players, or the media), partly due to perceptions of unethical behavior (e.g. Rick said expansion showed “no loyalty to the game”; Linda on how Chara “screwed” his teammate).

Regarding barriers to fan practices (6), brand loyalty theories suggest brand loyalty is set within the context of competing brands, and if the preferred brand becomes more difficult to acquire, or a different brand is discovered that promises more satisfaction, switching brands becomes a logical option (Dick & Basu, 1994; Shukla, 2009). In our case, we heard stories of switching to competing brands during the 2004-05 Lockout- typically other major professional teams in football, baseball, basketball, or soccer leagues that provided sporting competition at a time the NHL was not. We also found former fans who discovered new sporting options (e.g. Steve with basketball and soccer) that provided higher levels of satisfaction than hockey, resulting in a switch to a different sport.

Implications

While our research goal was not to generate practical suggestions for marketing practitioners, some emerged. First, even though our unit of analysis was former NHL team fans, the number one category of reasons for de-escalation was league-based. Considering the number

of people turned-off in part by the NHL’s expansion into non-traditional hockey markets, leagues wishing to expand should carefully weigh the benefits of potentially developing new fans in new places, with the potential consequences of alienating some current dedicated supporters. As well, considering all 10 of our 23 participants who entered the 2004-05 seasons as dedicated fans cited the Lockout as contributing to ending their fandom, we must warn leagues not to presume all highly identified fans would remain so after a long work stoppage. Second, we found support for the literature suggesting fan identification can de-escalate due to poor team management (Fink et al., 2009). In our case, “de-escalate” eventually became the complete severing of the team-fan bond. While teams may want to believe highly identified fans will be loyal forever, care must be taken to embrace an overall philosophy of respecting the fan base, lest they end up with fewer fans. Third, an opportunity exists for leagues that ban fighting (e.g. high school and college hockey in North America) to market themselves as an alternative for former NHL fans turned-off by the mayhem many feel the NHL embodies. Based on our findings, such “non-fighting” leagues may find success in appealing to parents with messages stressing they provide a form of hockey parents could feel good about bringing children to see.

Limitations and Directions for Future Research

The research sample was predominantly well-educated, white, male Ontario residents. People in other demographic categories may tell different stories. As well, this study was not longitudinal, so we were unable to study people currently in the process of team identification de-escalation. Instead, we relied on recollections of a process that may have started decades ago, coupled with speculations on what may or may not influence them to become fans again in the future. We must acknowledge both that memories may fade, and predictions might not come true. Ideally, future research into this phenomenon should involve a more diverse sample studied

longitudinally to not only capture the essence of de-escalation as it happens, but also follow the fans in the years before and after. As well, our findings are based on former NHL team fans’ stories. While we acknowledge that the nature of play in the NHL results in specific issues not necessarily found in other sports or leagues (e.g. greed personified by losing an entire season to a labor dispute; fighting as a tactic, etc.), we believe the seven themes in general and the misalignment of fan values (5)/barriers to fan practices (6) in particular, might apply to other sports, leagues, and teams. Former fans should be studied world-wide to see the similarities and differences across sports, leagues, teams, nations, and cultures.

Directions for future research are numerous. In particular, is the potential to investigate how sport fans maintain fandom. Because fandom is not static, maintaining a strong fan identity to a team needs to be continually managed and developed. This sport fan “work” offers a new direction to fan researchers who can study the micro-processes that fans use to reinforce and recreate their identities. The study of sport fan “work” can lead not only to more process-oriented studies of fans and how they engage with teams, other fans, and non-fans as they reinforce their fandom and overcome obstacles that might lead to de-escalation, but also help test the first stage of our model (maintaining fandom).

Another investigative avenue concerns fans switching loyalties from one team to another in the same league, or having simultaneous loyalties to multiple teams. For example, before becoming non-fans, five of the 23 switched loyalties from one favorite NHL team to another and one had simultaneous loyalties to two teams. (Jim cheered for the Sabres until their season ended- often early- then followed the high-flying New York Islanders through the playoffs.) The “team-switching” phenomenon deserves attention, both on its own and with respect to the topic

at hand. For example, are team-switchers more likely to completely de-escalate, than those still loyal to their original team?

Another theme concerns civic loyalty living on after fandom ends. While emerging solely from two people who once cheered for their local “small-market” team, who still live nearby, the theme suggests other differences between fans of small-market teams versus big-market teams may exist. Future researchers should study these two groups to uncover any contextual differences between them.

Finally, the finding that children may socialize parents or grandparents into becoming fans of specific teams suggests it might be rewarding to study the intersection of parenting and fandom. For example, is being a “good” sports fan usually congruent with being a “good” parent? If so, does the ending of fandom result in any incongruencies with respect to parenting? While some sport consumer behavior research touches on such questions (Gibson et al., 2002), a study specifically designed to understand the overlapping issues between fandom and parenting could provide fascinating insights.

While we acknowledge the study’s limitations, we believe it makes a strong contribution to the field of sport consumer behavior as it adds to our understanding of the lived experience of an under-studied consumer segment. While certainly not all highly-identified fans will eventually stop cheering for their favorite team, academics would be remiss if we did not try to understand those who do. Hearing their stories will help us develop a better theoretical perspective of the entire sport fan process.

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Appendix A: Participant Profiles

Pseudo-nym	Former fan of	Age	Gender	Race	Occupation	Family Status	Residence where fandom developed	Residence where fandom ended	Education
Max	Canadiens	20	Male	Caucasian	University student	Single	Small town, Nova Scotia	Same	Some college/university
Steve	Red Wings	25	Male	Caucasian	Graduate student	Single	Small town, South-Western Ontario	London, Ontario	College/university graduate
Rick	Canadiens	58	Male	Caucasian	Retired pipefitter	Married	Sudbury, Ontario	Small town, Niagara Region, Ontario	College/university graduate
Reid	Maple Leafs	21	Male	African Canadian	University student	Other	Toronto, Ontario	Same	Some college/university
Walt	Red Wings	21	Male	Caucasian	University student	Single	Guelph, Ontario	Same	Some college/university
Kurt	Leafs/Oilers	49	Male	Caucasian	Professor	Other	Red Deer, Alberta	Edmonton, Alberta	Advanced degree
Jerry	Leafs/Canadiens Oilers	46	Male	Caucasian	Golf pro	Married	St. Catharines, Ontario	Same	College/university graduate
Ralph	Bruins	52	Male	Caucasian	Professor	Single	Small town, Mid-Western Ontario	Boston, Massachusetts	Advanced degree
Susan	Leafs/Senators	66	Female	Caucasian	Retired farmer	Married	Small town, Mid-Western Ontario	Small town, South-Western Ontario	College/university graduate
Royce	Leafs	33	Male	Caucasian	Software consultant	Single	Toronto, Ontario	Montreal, Quebec	Advanced degree
Linda	Oilers/Senators	44	Female	Caucasian	Writer/Editor	Married	Ottawa, Ontario	Same	College/university graduate
Billy	Leafs	20	Male	Caucasian	University student	Single	Toronto, Ontario	Same	Some college/university
Ray	Leafs	61	Male	Caucasian	Managem't VP	Married	Grimsby, Ontario	Burlington, Ontario	College/university graduate
Lisa	Leafs	36	Female	Caucasian	Professor	Married	St. Catharines, Ontario	Hamilton, Ontario	Advanced degree
Jim	Sabres/Islanders	46	Male	Caucasian	High school teacher	Single	Small city, Western New York	Suburb of Buffalo, New York	Advanced degree
Rodney	Leafs	38	Male	Caucasian	Auto mechanic	Married	Small town, Mid-Western Ontario	Kitchener, Ontario	College/university graduate
Blake	Stars	18	Male	Caucasian	University student	Single	Small town, South-Western Ontario	Same	Some college/university
Edward	Leafs/Penguins	37	Male	Caucasian	Information technology	Married	Small town, Niagara Region, Ontario	Same	College/university graduate
Bruce	Canadiens	50	Male	Caucasian	Writer/host	Divorced	Stoney Creek, Ontario	Same	High school graduate
Cliff	Canadiens/Leafs	62	Male	Asian/Other	Retired accountant	Married	St. Catharines, Ontario	Oakville, Ontario	Advanced degree
Dave	Leafs	58	Male	Caucasian	Government worker	Other	Hamilton, Ontario	Same	College/university graduate
Andy	Blackhawks	67	Male	Caucasian	Retired lawyer	Widowed	Windsor, Ontario	Moved frequently around N. America	Advanced degree
Carl	Oilers	59	Male	Caucasian	Teacher	Married	Small town, Mid-Western Ontario	Same	College/university graduate

Appendix B: Participants’ Reasons for Becoming a Non-fan

	Sports	Hockey	League	Team	Players	Media	Life
Max	x		x				x
Steve		x		x			x
Rick			x	x			x
Reid			x	x			x
Walt			x				x
Kurt	x			x	x	x	x
Jerry		x	x				
Ralph		x	x	x			x
Susan			x			x	x
Royce						x	x
Linda			x		x		x
Billy			x				x
Ray			x	x			
Lisa		x	x	x	x	x	
Jim	x		x		x	x	
Rodney			x				
Blake		x	x	x			x
Edward							x
Bruce			x		x		
Cliff			x	x		x	
Dave			x				x
Andy			x				x
Carl			x				
Total	3	5	19	9	5	6	15

Figure 1: Conceptual Model of Sport Fan De-escalation

